

enabled us to prepare for you what we believe has the potential to uproot that XP/Vista thing out of your system—only if you're willing to give it a try by learning and unlearning a few things. Give it a day (or at the most, a week), and if you don't shy away from asking questions, we believe you can make it.

Getting started: The first-timers' guide

Now that you've popped in the CD and reset your computer, you'll be presented with a menu along with some information. Just hit "Boot KDE 4.3 Live CD" to boot into a live environment—i.e., boot the OS.

For starters, a live CD runs directly off the CD by loading the programs into your RAM, without touching your hard disk in any way. The minimum requirements are 512 MB of RAM and a decent CPU that's not more than half a decade old. Newer and more powerful hardware would, of course, perform better.

You'll now see a boot splash screen with a progress bar soon to be replaced by a licence agreement. Read it if you like—or just agree to it by hitting 'Yes' as most of us do anyway. Although, if you don't know the GPL, dedicating five minutes of your time to reading at least the first few paragraphs of the licence would make it more clear to you why free software is special.

After that, you'll go back to a black and white screen with some text scrolling. Don't panic—nothing is wrong here. You'll soon notice the graphical desktop start.

Yes, it's relatively empty—the only thing occupying the screen is a tiny panel at the bottom. Right click on the desktop and see what widgets you can run. I'd first recommend that you add the **Folder View** widget before anything else. This is like a container for your desktop folder, the place where you have all those icons, files and folders. The folder view comes in handy because even if you put your whole world on the desktop, everything is still accessible—nothing goes out of the screen because you get a scroll bar to help you navigate when this container fills up. Check out some other widgets if you like.

Hit the KDE menu (at the extreme left corner of the panel) to check all the applications we have for you. Here's a round up:

1. Office suite: OpenOffice.org 3.1
2. Browser: Mozilla Firefox 3.5.2 (besides Konqueror)
3. Audio player: Amarok 2.1.1
4. Video player: SMPlayer
5. Image editing: GIMP 2.6 and Krita 2.0
6. Digital camera tool: Digikam
7. Image viewer: Gwenview
8. Personal information manager: Kontact (mail, RSS reader, organiser, etc.)
9. Video editor: Kdenlive

One CD! It has it all (well, almost)

Well, let me share a little secret! Most of our regular readers would know that we generally bundle a KDE 4 Live CD (based on openSUSE) with the LFY issue that follows the specific KDE version release. The plan was the same this time.

The KDE Live CD has all sorts of pure KDE applications—but nothing else. For example, it doesn't have the OpenOffice.org (OOo) office suite nor Firefox. So, if you plan to install the CD, it means you'll have to download these two, for sure. Besides, most Linux distros don't bundle multimedia codecs out-of-the-box due to patent restrictions in some parts of the globe—just as with the KDE Live CD. Thankfully, in India, we don't have software patent laws! So, why should we be deprived, and unnecessarily spend on bandwidth to make the system usable?

I'll share another little secret: Pardus 2009 is perhaps one of the best drop-in replacements for your general desktop OS. It comes with the KDE 4.2.4, OOo 3.1 and Firefox 3.5.1, besides all sorts of multimedia codecs. The only issue with it is that it was released before KDE 4.3 came out! So, we stole their concept, and aided by the release of SUSE Studio, we created our own Pardus replacement. Unfortunately, since none of us are developers here, our overall desktop integration is not as good as that of Pardus'.

10. Disc burning tool: K3b

Besides these, there's a chat client (Kopete), download manager (KGet), BitTorrent client (KTorrent), a PDF and document viewer (Okular), and various system and other miscellaneous tools.

There's support for compressing and uncompressing RAR, ZIP, LZMA, BZ2, GZ, etc, files aided by the Ark utility. Whether your music collection includes songs in MP3, ogg, wav and flac formats, Amarok should be able to manage all of them. SMPlayer will play most of the MPEG, DivX, XviD, MP4, flv, ogv, wmv, and other content you throw at it, apart from its ability to play encrypted DVD videos. Besides, you can play YouTube videos using Firefox.

I don't know what else you do, so please feel free to check the menu for applications. Here's a simple trick: hit Alt+F2 and in the pop-up box, fill in a term like, for example, 'audio' and see what application plays audio. Yes, you can launch that application straight from this tool.

To set your desktop properties, hit the KDE menu and launch **Configure Desktop**. You can finetune your desktop from there. Besides, the systems admin tool called YaST is where you can make system-level (as opposed to user-level) changes like configuring your network. The administrator (root) password is linux. So, if your system doesn't get its IP address